Westbrook City Council

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Monday, April 6, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1180610906
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_04062026-995

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Mayor's FY2026-2027 Budget Address

Proposed FY27 Budget (Not Yet Adopted) [1:36]

Discussion Summary

Municipal: proposed expenditures $39,088,502 (+6.48%); non-tax revenues $21,888,623 (+3.56%); net municipal tax need $17,199,879 (+8.41% cumulative).

School (as of Apr. 3, not final): PreK–12 expenditures $57,871,667 (+8.47%); adult education $662,508 (+6.52%); non-taxpayer revenues $23,129,659 (+7.69%); net school tax need $35,404,516 (+8.96%).

TIF & county: projected TIF revenue $7,235,128 (+6.62%); Cumberland County assessment $2,413,846 (+12.37%) — the Mayor attributed the county jump to lost federal U.S. Marshals Service revenue tied to the jail's ICE-detainee housing contract.

Bottom line: total property tax need $62,253,369, up $4,960,698 (8.66%). Citywide valuation is projected flat (real estate gains offset by declining personal property value), implying a tax rate increase of $1.30 per $1,000 assessed value (8.63%) — about **$463 more per year** for a median-value Westbrook home ($355,160). The Homestead Exemption is projected to decline from $22,500 to $20,750 (assessed ratio ~83%), with a return to the full exemption expected in 2029 after a 2028 citywide revaluation. All figures are estimates pending final valuation and the June 9 school budget referendum.

Staffing decisions: of two Fire Dept. retirements anticipated for 2026, only one occurred, leaving actual strength at 47 (up from 46); the FY27 budget funds making that 47-position strength permanent, since TIF funds can cover a temporary but not sustainable long-term increase. Of two requested Public Services positions, a new Operations Supervisor was approved (funded nine months) and an Equipment Operator I position was denied, to be revisited next year. Project management of the regional fire training facility has been handed to Project Manager Robyn Saunders.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken; budget referred to Finance Committee (see Referrals below).

Action Items

None.

Proclamations

Armenian Genocide Commemoration Day & Westbrook-Gorham Rotary 100th Anniversary [19:36]

Discussion Summary

Mayor Morse proclaimed April 24, 2026 as Armenian Genocide Commemoration Day. Councilor Turcotte, granddaughter of genocide survivors, read a statement on behalf of Dr. Gary Zartarian of the Armenian National Committee of Maine thanking the City for its continued annual recognition.

The Mayor also proclaimed recognition of the Westbrook-Gorham Rotary Club's 100th anniversary (chartered March 8, 1926). Past president/current secretary Christine Johnson gave a detailed history, including the club's partnership with the Westbrook Regional Vocational Center since 1957 and local youth programs, and announced the 73rd Patriots Day Road Race (Apr. 20) and 32nd Rotary Classic Golf Tournament (Sept. 28).

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Fire Department Staffing: Chief's Statement & Firefighter Testimony

[31:17] Fire Chief Stephen Sloan opened with a prepared statement responding to a March 30 WMTW interview and a firefighters' union Facebook post, prompted by two recent structure fires (71 North Street, Mar. 19; Chestnut Street, Mar. 28 — both handled with nine firefighters on scene within six minutes, with mutual aid). He disputed a claim that staffing hasn't increased since 2004, noting growth from 4 full-time members/shift (24 total) in 2004 to 11–12/shift (46 total) today, while the contractual minimum of nine on duty has stayed constant. He called mutual aid a normal reciprocal regional function and said any staffing increase must be strategic and financially sustainable, citing comparable staffing in Biddeford, Brunswick, Saco, and Scarborough.

A succession of current and retired firefighters, several identifying with Teamsters Local 340 and the Westbrook Professional Firefighters Association (WPFA), presented a more urgent picture during public comment.

> *"This media release is a response to the statement issued by the City of Westbrook on March 31st, which seems to be a political walk back in the softening tone of the interview from Chief Sloan... The figure [nine firefighters] is only accurate if there is no vacations, no medical leave... In reality, staffing levels frequently operate at the minimum of nine... for 68% of the time last year. In 2001, the department responded to 3,000 calls for service, and last year we exceeded 5,200 with the same level of minimum staffing."*

— Captain Joe Carroll, reading a WPFA/Teamsters Local 340 press release [1:03:17]

> *“Minimum staffing is not a savings account, it is a liability... We did however lose that bet on March 19, 2026, as you all heard, on North Street, when all available resources were committed on other emergencies. The same happened five years previous on April 9, 2021, on Spears Street, when only Engine 3 with two members arrived at a house fire with reported and confirmed victim entrapment.”*

— Firefighter/Union Steward Caleb Young [56:38]

> *“68% of the time, this department operates with only nine firefighters on duty in the entire city... This is not new. We have been understaffed at multiple critical incidents in my short tenure... This very building we're in right now, we showed up with a minimum when there was a fire two floors above us.”*

— Firefighter Adam Vining (on duty during the North Street fire) [59:22]

Captain Mark Terriel, nearing retirement after roughly 30 years, described the first ten minutes of any call — before mutual aid can arrive — as the most critical, with only two fire trucks and two ambulances citywide and no incident command presence after hours. Councilor Chau, a 12–13 year council veteran, said the growth gap between city-side and school-side budgets in recent years concerned him given the stakes raised. In second public comment, Carroll clarified the evening's intent was to open a long-overdue collaborative conversation, not confrontation.

> *“It's important that these conversations don't start with a Facebook post... I'm open, and this is the memo that we received this afternoon, about an hour before the council meeting started, was the first request for collaboration this budget season... Joe, I would like to invite you, if you're free, you and I can have a sit down tomorrow.”*

— City Administrator Angela Holmes (response) [1:55:28]

Key Decisions

✓ No vote or formal Council action resulted from this discussion tonight.

Public Comment: Gorham's Proposed Amazon Warehouse

Traffic Impact Briefing from Gorham Residents [48:12]

Discussion Summary

Josh Trombley and Charlie Hample, both Gorham residents, briefed the Council on a roughly 94-acre land sale (approved by Gorham's Town Council in August 2025 with minimal public notice) for a proposed Amazon last-mile delivery warehouse (~150,000 sq. ft.) on Route 25/Main Street heading into Westbrook. Estimates cited ranged from 1,100–3,000 additional daily vehicle trips, with speakers suggesting most would route through Westbrook's Main Street toward the turnpike. The project still requires Planning Board, Maine DEP, MaineDOT, and Army Corps of Engineers approvals before the land sale is finalized.

Assistant City Administrator Jenny Franceschi confirmed Westbrook has been invited into the MaineDOT review process and will participate (with Director of Public Services Eric Dudley) to represent the City's interests on traffic impacts; no meeting date had been set yet. Councilor Turcotte asked about raising a previously-declined Gorham turnpike exit with MaineDOT; Mayor Morse called that “a can of worms” but said

the City would flag any overlooked solutions.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Staff Announcement

Rebecca Spatella Promoted to Director of Planning & Code Enforcement [42:26]

Discussion Summary

Spatella has been with the City since December 2017 (hired as Assistant Planner, promoted to Associate Planner in 2020 and Senior Planner in 2022), holds a master's in community planning and development from the USM Muskie School, and is AICP-certified. She succeeds Jenny Franceschi, who moved up to Assistant City Administrator (see the Mar. 16 meeting summary).

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2026-34, -35, -36 — Gym Floor, Riverwalk North & Brown Street Culvert (Consent) [1:14:17]

Discussion Summary

All first-read at the Mar. 16, 2026 meeting: Community Center gym floor refurbishment (two donations plus a $57,469 expenditure); Credere Associates Task Order No. 8 for Riverwalk North permitting/design ($211,500); and Brown Street culvert engineering design ($21,500) — see that meeting's summary for full detail. Several councilors again thanked the Cornelia Warren Community Association and Paper City Hoops for their gym-floor donations.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed together by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

New Business

Resolve 2026-09 — Election Hours — June 9, 2026 State Primary & School Budget Referendum [1:16:16]

Found on page 35 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Sets polls open 6 AM–8 PM on June 9, 2026, plus voter-registration hours at City Hall in the weeks before (including Saturday, May 16, 8 AM–noon, and Wednesday, June 3, 7:30 AM–7 PM).

Key Decisions
✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items
None.

Resolve 2026-10 — WEIC Reappointments [1:19:16]

Found on page 37 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Confirms reappointment of Stephen Noyes and Warren Lain to the Westbrook Environmental Improvement Corporation (WEIC) for four-year terms expiring Dec. 31, 2029.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-37 — Fowl & Poultry Ordinance (Tabled)

[1:21:48] Updates the Code of Ordinances to comply with a new state right-to-raise-chickens law while prohibiting roosters at residential properties (citing neighbor complaints relayed by incoming Animal Control Officer Brett Bissinet) and capping residential flocks at six birds (twelve in rural districts).

Councilor Chau flagged that the drafted enclosure-size requirement appeared to require a 1,000-square-foot *coop* for six chickens; several councilors and public commenter Steve Pulsoni suspected this was a drafting/punctuation error meaning a 1,000-square-foot *yard*, not coop. After discussion of enforcement timelines, coop-height requirements, and whether to sever just the disputed provision, the Council tabled the item to return with corrected language April 27. Councilor Turcotte pressed for a firm compliance deadline once re-drafted, rather than case-by-case enforcement, citing fairness to complaining neighbors.

Key Decisions
✓ Tabled, 6–1 (Councilor Chau opposed), to return April 27 with corrected language.

New Business (continued)

Order 2026-38 — Affordable Housing TIF Annual Reports [1:42:07]

Found on page 47 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Approves submission of required Affordable Housing TIF District annual reports to Maine State Housing for all affordable-housing TIFs active during the tax year (Larrabee Commons, Riverview Terrace, Harnois Apartments, Emery Apartments, Millbrook Estates, Avesta Seavey Street, Stroudwater Apartments, and Stacy M. Symbol Apartments).

Key Decisions

✓ **Approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-39 — Confined Space Rescue Program Donation [1:43:28]

Found on page 65 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Accepts a $30,000 donation from Calpine Energy, continuing the Fire Department's multi-year partnership with Calpine for confined-space rescue training and equipment.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-40 — Stryker Power-Load Stretcher [1:44:42]

Found on page 68 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Authorizes $42,987.63 for a Stryker Power Pro 2 stretcher, giving each ambulance in the fleet a dedicated stretcher; included in the FY2026 CIP.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-41 — General Obligation Bonds — Canal Elementary HVAC [1:46:11]

Found on page 73 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Authorizes up to $428,445 in bonds through the Maine Municipal Bond Bank's School Revolving Renovation Loan Fund to install ductless multi-zone mini-split HVAC systems at Canal Elementary School. Under this state program, the City is responsible for 51% of the loan, with the remaining 49% (and all interest) forgiven by the state.

Key Decisions
✓ **Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-42 — Land Use Ordinance — Child Care Uses (First Reading) [1:48:17]

Found on page 80 of the packet.

Discussion Summary
Amends the Land Use Ordinance to comply with new state law (raising the number of children a non-licensed provider may care for, and allowing nearby public open space to count toward a daycare's required outdoor play area) and to permit child care facilities in all zones where residential uses are allowed. Requires a public hearing at the April 27 meeting.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Referrals, Committee Reports & Adjournment

Budget Referral & Committee Report Cleanup [1:58:48]

Discussion Summary

The proposed FY2026-2027 budget was referred to the Finance Committee for review. Separately, City staff recommended removing several long-standing items from the Council's standing committee referral list: Residential Landlord Registration (pending state-level action), Austin Street Extension, and Central Street Traffic Concerns. Councilor McCambridge objected to also removing Haskell Street Traffic Calming, questioning the validity of an earlier traffic study conducted during nearby road construction; the Council amended the motion to keep that item on the list.

Key Decisions

✓ Residential Landlord Registration, Austin Street Extension, and Central Street Traffic Concerns removed from committee, by unanimous show of hands.

✓ Haskell Street Traffic Calming retained on the committee list at Councilor McCambridge's request.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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